Session 8

2025-03-23

1 - Past the barracks

~00:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Leaving **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**'s corpse behind in the columned chamber where he fell, the party crosses back to the barracks where they fought **Frulam Mondath** the day before.
2. From the corridor at the back of the barracks they catch the sound of something coming up. Eguzkilore readies an arrow on his bow, waiting on whatever clears the corridor mouth.
3. A *guard drake* bursts from the corridor and charges Eguzkilore. The elf's held arrow drives into the creature, but the drake covers the distance anyway and reaches him in melee.
4. Now with the drake at sword's reach, Eguzkilore lets the bow fall and draws his scimitar, then brings the blade down on the creature in one full swing — the cut runs as deep as the steel can carry.
5. Nuberroca charges in, weaving through the others to get to the drake — a few paces shy of the cleaner flanking angle, but he engages from where he can with **Langdedrosa**'s greatsword. The blow lands cleanly.
6. Nyx steps to a fresh angle between two of the room's beds and lines a clean bow shot into the drake.
7. The drake turns on Nuberroca with a bite and a tail-strike — both fail utterly; from across the chamber Sinsong answers with a *bolt of fire* at the drake.
8. Nuberroca, swinging recklessly, brings the greatsword up and down in a single arc and severs the drake's head clean from its body.
9. Nyx listens for what else is in the cave. Beyond the constant water-drip and cave noise, she picks out the soft beat of *wings* from the corridor the party came down — faint but distinct, larger than a bat.

2 - Frulam's quarters

1. The party advances cautiously into the chamber beyond the doorway. Nyx slips into the room with stealth; Eguzkilore moves up with her; Sinsong follows behind. Nuberroca, badly hurt from the previous fight, hangs back and asks aloud to be patched up.
2. Past the doorway lie two adjoining chambers, both *elegantly appointed* by the standards of the cult camp. The main room holds a writing table laid with several notes and a map, and a bookshelf along the wall. The bedroom beyond has a large bed and two chests — the clothing scattered around the bed reads as a woman's. Both rooms are empty of cultists.
3. Sinsong, scanning the floor, gets fixated on a small *yellow rug* tucked along the wall that does not match any of the other rug-and-furniture pairings in the chamber.
4. Sinsong steps onto the yellow rug to take a closer look. The rug gives way under his weight; he plunges through a concealed hole in the floor. At the last moment he catches hold of a rope hanging in the shaft and stops his fall.
5. Sinsong drags himself back up the rope into the chamber. He tells the others what he saw at the bottom of the shaft: a *gigantic statue*, an altar before it, and at least one drake with kobolds around it. Based on his mental map, he thinks the chamber down there can also be reached around from another way.
6. Nyx investigates the bookshelf and pulls out a *book on dragons* the cultists had been keeping. She slips it into her pack to read in her own time. After that, the halfling gathers up the loose notes from the table and pockets the map as well.
7. While the others search, Sinsong asks Nuberroca to push the drake's corpse to block the corridor, then Nuberroca shoves the bookshelf across the bedroom door as a rough barricade. From across the room Nyx watches *winged kobolds* pour out of the shaft and mutters in resignation — *"la barricada más inútil del mundo"*.

3 - The winged kobolds

1. A kobold throws a net at Eguzkilore while he stands over the hole. The throw catches him *cleanly* — he is tangled in the netting, unable to move.
2. A second kobold flutters over the elf and hurls a rock straight at the restrained Eguzkilore. The stone lands hard.
3. Another stone catches the elf archer square in the head; **Eguzkilore collapses unconscious, still tangled in the net**. Another rock follows — Sinsong is the target this time; the throw goes wide.
4. Nyx steps to the kobold pressing through the shaft and runs it through with her sword; it falls dead at her feet.
5. Sinsong calls a *spectral sword* into the air at his side, and the blade strikes the kobold pressing next to him from a flanking angle. He then crosses to Eguzkilore, lays a hand on him and steadies the elf's bleeding with a magic word, before falling back behind the writing table into cover.
6. Three kobolds press in around Nyx, two flanking her for a coordinated strike — one strike gets through and lands hard, drawing blood. She strikes the kobold on her right, killing it. Another disengages and slips towards the shaft; Nyx hacks it as it goes, but the kobold survives the hit and disappears through the hole.
7. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* across at the last kobold pressing Nyx — the blade strikes home and obliterates the creature. He then crosses to Eguzkilore and casts a healing spell on the elf — barely enough to bring him back, but the elf cracks his eyes open.
8. Nuberroca plants himself with one foot either side of the shaft and *rips the net* off Eguzkilore with his bare hands. He hauls the elf up: *"venǵa, Eǵuzkilore, espabila, que todavía queda trabajo por hacer"*.
9. Nyx, remembering she had not done it the day before, hands one of her *maǵical berries* to each of them — one bite is enough to revive a teammate at the *threshold of life*.
10. Nyx asks aloud whether they should block the trapdoor or go down to the lower chamber; Sinsong suggests they barricade it. Nuberroca drops the heavy table over the shaft mouth to seal it for the moment.
11. The barbarian moves to the two chests in the corner: he checks the first for traps and opens it — empty. Nyx tries the second herself and finds only **women's clothing**. Eguzkilore walks the kobold bodies on the floor and pockets the meagre valuables they have.

4 - Down the rope

1. With the upper room cleared and the trapdoor barricade shoved aside, Sinsong sends his *spectral sword* down the shaft and swings it blindly in the dark — the sword has no senses of its own and finds nothing. The shaft is a *thirty feet* drop.
2. Sinsong lowers himself down the rope and ends his descent at about ten feet above the floor, where a drake below jumps to snap at him — *both bites fail*. He tries to climb back up, but Nuberroca, who has come down behind him into the shaft mouth, is jammed shoulder-to-shoulder across the tunnel above him — Sinsong cannot climb past the goliath.
3. Nyx descends the rope until she reaches Nuberroca, lets go of it, and steps up onto the goliath's shoulders so her hands are free for the bow. From that unstable perch she draws on the drake, the shot harder for the footing.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx's arrow threads the narrow gap between Nuberroca's shoulder and the wall of the shaft. Exactly as the drake lifts a claw at Sinsong below, the arrow drives into the drake's paw — the kind of shot nobody quite expects to land.
5. Sinsong slips past the drake's reach, repositions on the floor, and the spectral sword strikes the drake from a flanking angle.
6. With the shaft below clear, Nuberroca drops the rest of the way to the floor, takes up the flanking position, and brings the greatsword down on the drake. Nyx comes off the rope behind him and her arrow lands too.
7. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* in again and follows with a *bolt of fire* for a small burn. The drake answers with one last bite at Nuberroca and slips wide. Nuberroca grips Sinsong's shoulder and a measure of his fury passes through, hardening him against the next blow; then he brings the greatsword down on the drake between them — the killing blow. The tunnel to the chamber is clear.

5 - Tiamat's chamber

1. With the drake down, the four take in the room properly. Three of the four walls and the floor are *tooled smooth* and run with damp. Bas-relief *dragons* are carved across the smooth walls, their tails knotting around one another in long looping patterns; the ceiling is left in its raw cave form.
2. The chamber's centrepiece is a vast statue of a *five-headed dragon*, each head a different make, the creature climbing out of an erupting volcano; smaller dragons in the carving fly around its flanks. Sinsong, with the right schooling, recognises **Tiamat** at once.
3. A small *wooden chest*, well-made and decorated, sits on the floor in the corner of the chamber, in front of the statue.
4. Sinsong, looking longer at the walls than the others, notices something off about the dragon carvings — there are *more black dragons than any other breed*, perhaps one in three. Nyx wonders aloud what elemental type they are but nobody at the table has the lore, so she tries to find the info on her new book.
5. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* across to strike the chest. The blow drives the chest a hand's-breadth sideways, and the statue takes a small chip in the same arc. *Click.*
6. From the chamber rises a long *hissing* — like *the tongue of a serpent, but a hundred at once* — and then, from the mouths of every black dragon carved into the walls, a pale liquid spits out, *eating the stone wherever it touches*. The whole chamber is sprayed with it.
7. As the acid pours, the party throws themselves clear. Nuberroca's instincts pull him out faster than the others, and the party fares well — only a brief burn on each of them, and they shake the worst of it off. The burn breaks Sinsong's hold on the *spectral sword*, however, and the blade dissolves into the air.
8. The acrid *vapour* created is the worse half of the trap. They hold their breath against it and ride it out — Eguzkilore catches the worst of the cloud. After a brief, agonising moment, the acid disperses.
9. Nyx's *dragon book* is ruined by the spray, as the halfling was checking it when the trap triggered. Half its pages are eaten away. She tucks what is left back into her pack.
10. Nuberroca checks the chest for traps and decides the lock has some sort of *spring* mechanism more elaborate than a chest of this kind warrants. He sets his shield, takes the scimitar, and brings the pommel down hard on the lock. The lock breaks — but nothing further fires.
11. Nyx focuses past the cave-noise and catches two distinct sounds: *kobolds* down one corridor, *drakes* down another. She points each direction out for the others.

6 - The hatchery

1. From the *darkness* to the east a single *kobold* emerges, lifts the key off a hook on the wall and turns it in a *barred iron gate* on the right side of the chamber. Beyond the bars Nyx makes out shapes that look like *eggs* — larger than a halfling.
2. As the kobold turns the key in the gate, two *drakes* answer it with a long roar from the deeper passage. Another kobold follows on its heels.
3. Eguzkilore advances and puts an arrow into the first drake. Sinsong's bolt of fire takes a kobold cleanly across the floor.
4. Nuberroca plants himself in the corridor mouth and brings the greatsword down with full force on one of the kobolds — the blow lands true and deep.
5. The drakes shift to pin Nuberroca from two sides. The first drake catches him with a bite and a tail-strike; a *blue glow* runs across each fresh cut and closes it partway. Nuberroca is still badly hurt, but his fury holds the worst of it back.
6. From the bend, Nyx puts a *clean hard arrow* into the first drake and drops it dead — the arrow is left lodged in its head. Nuberroca lets out a clearly audible breath.
7. The second drake repositions to flank Nuberroca and presses again — bite and tail. The blows land, but his fury holds.
8. Sinsong, from cover, hurls a *bolt of fire* at the surviving drake — a long, roaring stream that arcs past Nuberroca's cheek and tears clean into the creature. *"Os he vuelto a salvar"*.
9. Nuberroca brings the greatsword down on the wounded drake. The east passage is clear.
10. Nyx walks the bodies afterward and recovers two of her arrows from the kobolds. Eguzkilore recovers one of his own. Sinsong gathers the four of them in close and weaves a *bonded blessing* over them.

7 – Behind the iron gate

1. The party walks up to the *iron gate* the kobold had opened. The key is hanging on a hook nearby. Through the bars Nyx makes out three *eggs*, roughly a metre tall each, in straw, and *blood-stains* on the floor that *do not look fresh*. The chamber beyond stretches out past the reach of their light.
2. Nyx asks the group whether they want to go in and investigate. Eguzkilore wants in; Nuberroca cautions them to enter with care, in stealth and in the shadows.
3. Eguzkilore eases through the gate and down the few steps into the egg chamber, treading carefully so as not to make a sound.
4. Sinsong calls for action: he raises a *bolt of fire* at one of the eggs and the **straw under it catches**. The egg itself stays intact in the flame.
5. Nuberroca strides over to the burning egg and brings the greatsword down two-handed. The shell splits and a *half-formed dragon hatchling* crawls out, manages a single rasping attempt at breath, and *dies* on the floor. He looks at the others, tears a small wing from the body and tries to *cook it over the burning straw*.
6. Nyx, watching the goliath cook a half-formed dragon, walks back to the iron gate and quietly takes the key off the hook on the wall, slipping it into her pocket. In case something goes wrong, she explains, they can run out and close the gate. Nuberroca approves.
7. Eguzkilore drifts over to join Nuberroca and asks if there is anything else worth taking off the hatchling — a scale, a claw. There is not. He sits down with the goliath and the two of them set about cooking a slice of half-formed dragon over the burning straw.
8. While the two cook, Nyx puts the question to the group plainly: should they *destroy* the remaining eggs so they cannot grow up and cause harm later, or leave them? Nuberroca floats *taking one with them* instead.

8 – The living column

1. To the east of the chamber one of the cave columns *begins to move*. A long *tentacle* unfurls from it, snakes across the floor to the broken egg, hooks the dead hatchling and drags it back — *"comida"*.
2. The party reads it for what it is — **a Roper** — a column-shaped predator, frankly large and, at least for the moment, only interested in eating.
3. Eguzkilore breaks for the gate at a dash, calling for Nyx to ready the key. Sinsong, behind cover, lobs another *bolt of fire* at a different egg as bait — the straw beneath it catches too.
4. Nuberroca cracks open the recently ignited egg with the greatsword; another half-formed hatchling, like the first, fails its first breath and dies on the floor. He gestures at the Roper and points to the body — *"comida"*.
5. The Roper crawls slowly toward the gate, hooks the second hatchling on a tentacle and eats it on the move.
6. Sinsong slips outside the gate, swings it shut behind him, and through the bars hurls a final *bolt of fire* at the Roper. The creature shudders under the flame; from its bulk dozens of fresh tentacles boil up, *writhing*.
7. Tentacles whip out across the chamber. The first volley mostly fails, but a second wave catches Nuberroca cleanly — and where it touches, tiny *needles* drive into the skin and *drain the strength* out of him. Later strikes catch Eguzkilore as well and pull him hard against the iron gate; the gate strains but holds.
8. The Roper *climbs the ceiling* and crosses through the gap above the iron gate, stretching its body over the bars. From the new vantage it reaches tentacles to both sides — biting Nuberroca on the way through, a heavy blow, even with his fury blunting the worst of it. A *blue glow* flickers across the bite as it opens, but the wound outpaces it. The goliath is staying upright on fury alone. Another tentacle grapples Nyx.
9. Nuberroca *dissolves into a wisp of cloud* out of the monster's grip and reforms behind Nyx. He plants himself and tears the tentacle off her by main strength.
10. Nyx hurls the last two *rations* in her pack at the Roper as bait. A clean, vicious tentacle catches Nyx in the same moment, but the Roper's hunger overrides the rest of its attacks — it drags the food in with two tentacles and eats them in two bites.
11. Eguzkilore cuts free of the tentacle that has him and moves toward the shrine's chamber, but the path is jammed with Sinsong at the doorway and he can advance no further.

9 - A chance to scape

1. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong, with the situation about to get past the party, *weaves a binding of sleep* over the Roper. The creature's tentacles slacken; it slumps where it stands — stupor deep enough to hold for a while, as long as no one strikes it.
2. With the Roper slumped from Sinsong's binding, Eguzkilore breaks past him and dashes the rest of the way out.
3. Nuberroca takes the moment Sinsong's *sleep* has bought and crosses back to the wooden chest. The thing is heavy — *sixty pounds* — but he gathers it under one arm and falls back toward the rope, his stride halved by the load.
4. Nyx still has the key in her pocket, but the gate was already shut from when Sinsong slipped out, and with the Roper slumped across the gap on the ceiling, locking it would change nothing. She turns away from the bars and falls in with the rest of the retreat.
5. The four of them work their way back to the shaft and start the climb up — Nyx leads, Eguzkilore and Sinsong behind her, Nuberroca with the chest. The Roper, behind them, stays where it slumped.